

Georgia's Supported Employment Workgroups Address the Obstacles to their Vision of a Better Future for Integrated Employment Outcomes

Background

The Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS) Home and Community Based Services (HCBS) rule passed to ensure people receiving waiver services are integrated into their communities. Georgia encountered competitive integrated employment barriers when they began implementing efforts to comply with the CMS HCBS rule. A thorough look at Georgia's state data has revealed clues to persistently low employment rates. As a result, Georgia brought workgroups together to explore competitive integrated employment solutions for people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD).

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What Happened

Georgia adopted its Employment First Act in May 2018, which recognizes competitive integrated employment as the first and preferred option for Georgians of working age with IDD receiving publicly funded services. Although Georgians with IDD and those who support them have advocated persistently for more competitive integrated employment outcomes, employment trends have not increased quickly.

Georgia's Department of Behavioral Health and Developmental Disability (DBHDD) reviewed state data from recent years to understand what was happening. They found long-term steady rates for people enrolled in waiver services showing 15% receiving supported employment services and 11% in competitive integrated employment. The individuals receiving either supported employment or competitive integrated employment services work in a variety of industries, typically for up to 15 hours a week, and have long tenures and low levels of support needs.

However, many more people say they want to work compared to those who have an employment goal. Georgia's National Core Indicators data shows 11% of individuals having a paid job in the community, 46% of unemployed individuals reporting they want a job, and only 9% who report wanting a job having an employment goal in their service plan.

"It was evident that individuals with higher support needs were either not being offered the opportunity to engage in Supported Employment services or were being denied services from our Supported Employment providers," says Christine Gudgin, Georgia's SELN lead contact and Supported Employment director at DBHDD. "We knew that part of the reason was the rate methodology used to pay providers to incentivize working with individuals with fewer support needs who can and want to work more hours per week." DBHDD also recognized that many people were not working because they had been placed indefinitely in pre-vocational services and facility-based Community Access Groups.

In May, DBHDD began a series of virtual and in-person workgroups to envision the future of competitive integrated employment for all Georgians with IDD. DBHDD still hosts these sessions. Facilitators from the State Employment Leadership Team (SELN) lead these workgroup sessions, including John Butterworth and Staci Jones (Institute for Community Inclusion) (SELN) and Teja Stokes (National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services).

The workgroups include people with disabilities, their families, business leaders, and service provider agencies, and the Department of Vocational Rehabilitation. The workgroups discuss community-facilitated services, community support services, rate methodologies, and business alliances. They also discuss how community services for a meaningful day can support employment services, including through a clear path from non-work to employment services.

Workgroup participants report finally feeling heard and having their fears addressed, feeling engaged in the process, and feeling appreciated as partners making change in Georgia. From the state agencies' perspective, SELN's facilitation allows agency administrators and staff the time to just listen and learn from the contributors. The objective is to distill the information and ideas from these discussions into attainable, 1-5-year goals, specifically in the areas of communication, systems navigation, and workforce development.

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Beyond the official workgroups, the DBHDD invited providers, Participant-Directed vendors/ individuals, families, self-advocates, businesses, or state agencies to send in written statements of their thoughts on the future of competitive integrated employment in Georgia to Christine Gudgin, Supported Employment Manager, Division of IDD, at Christine.Gudgin@dbhdd.ga.gov.

Questions and Next Steps

1. What is your state data telling you about different types of employment outcomes? What factors affect the success of employment service cases?
2. Who are employment service providers most likely to serve and why?
3. What are 2-3 broad priorities for your state to address to improve employment outcomes?
4. How could your state make effective use of workgroups and contributor comments to address employment gaps?



**State Employment
Leadership Network**



The SELN is a place for states to connect, collaborate, and create cross-community support regarding pressing employment-related issues at state and federal levels for individuals with developmental disabilities.

The SELN was launched in 2006 as a joint program of the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services and the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston.

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